Practice questions

Exam code: 9BS0

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Practice 8-mark questions for the 2025 exam

- Have a look at our guide to structuring your 8-mark answer
- Mark allocation
  - Knowledge 2; application 2, analysis 2; evaluation 2
- Use the example source booklet to answer the following questions

Theme 1 (Marketing and People)

Question	Information

Assess two ways an independent record store could build a strong brand identity to gain customer loyalty (8)	• **Pre-release link**: Indie retailers rely on events like Record Store Day and community "feel"
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 1.3.2 Branding and promotion
	  ○ 1.3.5 Marketing strategy

Assess how knowledgeable and passionate staff in HMV stores can enhance customer experience and brand loyalty (8)	• **Pre release link**: HMV focuses on "experiential" retail and invests in staff expertise.
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 1.4.4 Motivation in theory
	  ○ 1.1.3 Market positioning

Theme 2 (Managing Business Activities)

Question	Information
Assess the importance of controlling operational costs for a boutique	• **Pre-release link**: Brackenwood faces variable costs, including

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

	◦ 2.2.4 Budgets ◦ 2.4.1 Production, productivity, efficiency (cost control)
Assess how the rise in vinyl demand could influence stock management decisions for major music retailers such as HMV	• **Pre-release link**: Physical inventory management for vinyl pressings vs. declining CD sales • **Syllabus link** ◦ 2.4.3 Stock control ◦ 1.1.1 The market (dynamic changes)

Theme 3 (Business Decisions and Strategy)

Question	Information
Assess how HMV's diversification into live events, merchandise and apparel might help it to maintain competitiveness in a streaming-focused market	• **Pre-release link**: HMV's "experiential" approach aims to differentiate from streaming services • **Syllabus link** ◦ 3.1.2 Theories of corporate strategy (diversification) ◦ 3.2.1 Growth objectives
Assess how boutique festivals might address the challenge of rising artist fees and security costs	• **Pre-release link**: Smaller festivals face competition from larger events with bigger budgets • **Syllabus link** ◦ 3.2.4 Reasons for staying small ◦ 3.1.1 Corporate objectives

Theme 4 (Global Business)

Question	Information

platforms to launch local artists onto global streaming charts	international exposure
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 4.2.1 Conditions prompting trade (pull factors)
	  ○ 4.2.2 Assessment of a country as a market

Assess how the global popularity of streaming may affect UK-based festival promoters trying to attract overseas visitors and international sponsors	• **Pre-release link**: Festivals compete globally for artists and audiences, building brand presence abroad
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 4.3.1 Global marketing strategy
	  ○ 4.4.1 Impact of MNCs (global competition)

Help me understand

Practice 10-mark questions for the 2025 exam

- Have a look at our guide to structuring your 10-mark answer
- Mark allocation
  - Knowledge 2; application 2, analysis 3; evaluation 3
- Use the example source booklet to answer the following questions

Theme 1 (Marketing and People)

Question	Information

Assess the extent to which improved staff training at HMV could boost employee motivation and store sales	• **Pre-release link**: HMV's strategy to make in-store shopping an experience
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 1.4.2 Recruitment, selection, training
	  ○ 1.4.4 Motivation in theory

Assess the effectiveness of independent record shops' niche marketing techniques in attracting customers in a streaming-dominated market	• **Pre-release link**: "We don't just sell records; we sell a sense of community"
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 1.1.1 Mass vs. niche markets
	  ○ 1.3.5 Marketing strategy

Assess how robust financial planning could help smaller festivals like Brackenwood achieve long-term viability	• **Pre-release link**: Weather and last-minute logistics can disrupt budgets severely
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 2.1.4 Planning (business plans, cash-flow)
	  ○ 2.3.3 Business failure

Assess the significance of production and distribution costs to record labels' long-term profitability	• **Pre-release link**: Rising interest in vinyl vs. potential plateau in demand
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 2.3.1 Profit (costs vs. revenue)
	  ○ 2.4.3 Stock control (fulfilling vinyl demand)

Theme 3 (Business Decisions and Strategy)

Question	Information

Assess how HMV's corporate objectives may conflict with short-term cost-cutting measures	• **Pre-release link**: HMV invests in in-store events, staff wages, and exclusives
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 3.1.1 Corporate objectives
	  ○ 3.1.2 Porter's Strategic Matrix / corporate strategy

Assess the extent to which collaborations with sponsors and local communities could help boutique festivals cope with rising operational costs	• **Pre-release link**: Festivals face growing security fees, artist demands, and logistics bills
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 3.6.1 Causes and effects of change
	  ○ 3.1.2 Ansoff's Matrix (joint ventures/partnerships)

Theme 4 (Global Business)

Question	Information
Assess how understanding viral social media trends could support a UK music retailer to target	• **Pre-release link**: TikTok can spark global interest in local tracks • **Syllabus link**

	prompting trade

Assess the potential benefits and drawbacks for UK festivals of partnering with international headliners and sponsors	• **Pre-release link**:Large festivals in the UK already attract worldwide fans, but cost and complexity rise
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 4.2.4 Reasons for global mergers or joint ventures
	  ○ 4.4.1 Impact of MNCs

Practice 12-mark questions for the 2025 exam

- Have a look at our guide to structuring your 12-mark answer
- Mark allocation
  - Knowledge 2; application 2, analysis 4; evaluation 4
- Use the example source booklet to answer the following questions

Theme 1 (Marketing and People)

Question	Information

Assess how a strong brand identity could help smaller independent record shops to attract customers, despite the popularity of streaming	• **Pre-release link**: Independent record stores focus on community, hosting live events, and limited-edition vinyl to stand out
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 1.3.2 Branding and promotion (building a brand)
	  ○ 1.1.3 Market positioning (competitive advantage)

Theme 2 (Managing Business Activities)

Question	Information
Assess the importance of careful budgeting for a small festival like Brackenwood	• **Pre-release link**: Brackenwood's budget is affected by last-minute infrastructure changes and tight finances • **Syllabus link** ○ 2.2.4 Budgets (purpose and difficulties)

	resources)

Theme 3 (Business Decisions and Strategy)

Question	Information

Assess how Lucy Graham's decision to keep Brackenwood Festival small and community-focused could affect its future success	• **Pre-release link**: Brackenwood stays local, invests in sustainability, and uses smaller acts instead of big-name headliners
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 3.2.4 Reasons for staying small (flexibility, niche appeal)
	  ○ 3.2.1 Growth objectives (trade-off between growth and control)

Theme 4 (Global Business)

Question	Information

Assess how viral social media trends might help UK artists reach fans in other countries	• **Pre-release link**: TikTok rapidly boosts songs to global audiences, but popularity can fade quickly
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 4.3.1 Global marketing (using social platforms for international reach)
	  ○ 4.2.1 Conditions that prompt trade (push/pull factors to enter new markets)

Practice 20-mark questions for the 2025 exam

- Have a look at our guide to structuring your 20-mark answer
- Mark allocation
  - Knowledge 4; application 4, analysis 6; evaluation 6
- Use the example source booklet to answer the following questions

Evaluate how HMV could use improved staff training and a broader product range to keep customers loyal in a streaming-led market. **Recommend** which strategy might most improve long-term sales	• **Pre-release link**: HMV trains passionate staff, diversifies into merchandise, in-store events, and exclusives
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 1.4.2 Recruitment, selection and training (staff expertise)
	  ○ 1.3.5 Marketing strategy (product ranges for different customers)

Theme 2 (Managing Business Activities)

Question	Information

Evaluate whether a small festival like Brackenwood should rely on external finance (e.g., bank loans or sponsors) to grow. In your answer, **recommend** the best funding approach to keep Brackenwood competitive	• **Pre-release link**: Brackenwood started via crowdfunding and local sponsorships but faces limited cash flow and higher costs
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 2.1.2 Raising finance (sources of external finance)
	  ○ 2.1.4 Planning (importance of a clear business plan for expansion)

Theme 3 (Business Decisions and Strategy)

Question	Information

differentiation (Porter's Strategic Matrix) to remain competitive. In your answer, **recommend** which strategic approach is likely to bring Brackenwood the greatest long-term success	eco-friendly but faces higher costs and strong rivals
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 3.1.2 Theories of corporate strategy (Porter's Strategic Matrix)
	  ○ 3.2.4 Reasons for staying small (USP, flexibility)

Theme 4 (Global Business)

Question	Information

Evaluate whether UK record retailers should sell vinyl abroad through international distribution partnerships or open a small chain of physical stores overseas to capitalise on the global vinyl boom. In your answer, **recommend** which of these two strategies is more likely to succeed in boosting brand awareness and profits abroad	• **Pre-release link**: Vinyl demand is growing worldwide; UK retailers such as HMV or independents could expand by partnering with foreign distributors or launching stores abroad
	• **Syllabus link**
	  ○ 4.2.5 Global competitiveness (differentiation vs. cost challenges, skill availability)
	  ○ 4.2.2 Assessment of a country as a market (ease of doing business, infrastructure, local demand)

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